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AGARWAL: Slogged hard on turning the tourist spot of Dilli Haat accessible. Now lobbying to make public transport disabled-friendly.

radar, dignity is what you make of it," says Deepa Malik.

Although paralytic below waist for the last nine years, she has proved her point—winning over 15 medals in sporting events across the world. The 38-year-old former beauty queen, swims, plays cricket and basketball, vrooms on her specially-designed bike and runs her own garden restaurant, Dees Place at Ahmednagar in Maharashtra. The army wife and a mother of two used to "feel guilty for being a burden to others" at one time. Then she changed her attitude. "Now I ask people to pick me up. The more people see us being picked up, the more they'll become sensitive to our needs," she feels.

"Take the airlines, for instance," says Abidi, who won a landmark case against the national carrier and forced it to provide wheelchair passengers with lifts. "Most airports don't have aerobridges. Wheelchair-users are often physically lifted and plonked on to seats toward the rear. Some even charge for this 'facility'," adds Gupta. Last month, on her way back from a swimming meet in Berlin, an airline refused to take Malik on board. She kicked up a ruckus and forced it to comply.

Mohit spends his evenings with his parents, discussing the future. The road ahead appears bumpy. A joint study by the Confederation of Indian Industry and Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) last year found that less than 1 per cent of the disabled actually have jobs in India and a majority earns less than Rs 2,000 a month. "The problem is, when the private sector comes calling, there's an incredibly small pool of people with requisite skills," says Gupta. "The schools for people with special needs often fail to equip them for new-economy jobs." But there's a turn in the tide. Companies in the high-growth sunrise sectors—IT, ITES, KPO, BPO,

hospitality, retail and telecom—have started tapping into this uncharted talent pools. Ask India's visually-impaired chess champ, Charudatta Jadhav. "I am judged on merit and I never ask for special consideration," says the associate consultant with TCS in Mumbai. Jadhav lost his vision when he was 13, but still managed to do a bachelor's in economics and a master's in computer applications. For the last few years, he has been trying to influence India Inc to provide jobs for the blind, especially in the software sector. "TCS has trained up six blind youth from Mumbai and nearly all have got jobs," says the man who received the Best Disabled Employee award from President A.P.J. Kalam in 2006.

Mohit has no problems being judged on merit. He knows he is good at art and that he can make friends fast ("I laugh a lot, you see"). But mindsets need to change for people like him to win through. Abidi recalls the war he waged with the Archeological Survey of India (ASI) way back in 2001, when renowned cosmologist, Stephen Hawking, came to India and wished to visit historical sites in Delhi. The ASI was forced to build ramps overnight for the paralysed scientist, although it took a slew of litigation to make those permanent. "The problem is, others start thinking for you," says Malik, "not because they are 'concerned', but because they think you can't

49% people with special needs are literate; only 6 per cent are graduate and above.

27% disabled people in India support their family as the chief breadwinner.

think of alternatives yourself."

Mohit is happy dreaming new dreams. But sometimes when his imagination fails he gets depressed. "I want to go abroad. Nobody bothers about us in this country," he says. The world is, after all, just a click away for him. Will the nation hold fast the ground beneath his feet? "I am a great believer in India and Indianness," says Abidi. "People used to stare at me and say, 'bechara' once. Now, I just have to say, 'Bhaisaab, please help'." Jadhav feels empathy wherever he goes. "One makes friends easily in India and they put you at ease," says Gupta. Agarwal, who has covered 48 cities on wheelchair, finds a lot more "acceptance" among people these days. Malik, who has just finished an one-kilometre swim across the Yamuna for Limca records, believes that she has forced people around her to change their attitude: "My paralysis is just a practical joke that destiny has played. I've forgiven my destiny. Others need to do the same," she laughs. Change, as they say, starts when someone sees the next step. ■